



WOMEN FACED MANY barriers when it came to taking part in exploration and travel in the past, but the one that proved most difficult to overcome was the view of women as “the weaker sex.” Where in the world a woman could go—and what was deemed appropriate for her to do or see at her destination—was too often dictated by her gender.

Historically, women took part in pilgrimages to religious shrines, or accompanied their husbands on military campaigns, but in times of exploration and conquest, often only followed their men to foreign countries after the conquest had been completed.

Adventurers turned writers

During the Age of Discovery (1450–1600) explorers such as Christopher Columbus were unwilling to take women—whom they considered both physically and intellectually unfit for exploration—into the unknown. From the 1700s, however, the growth of empires and trading links meant that the wives of pioneering men had more

◀ **Feminist mountaineer**

American mountaineer Annie Smith Peck was a passionate suffragist. When she reached the summit of Coropuna, Peru, in 1911 at the age of 65, she placed a “Votes for Women” banner on its peak.



▲ **Maverick aviator**

This pair of flying goggles was worn by aviator Amelia Earhart during her 1932 solo transatlantic flight. In a letter to her husband before her final flight in 1937 she said: “Women must try to do things as men have tried.”

opportunities to travel than their single (unaccompanied) counterparts. Some women resorted to cross-dressing in order to see the world—such as Louise Séguin, who in 1772–1773 became the first European woman to go to the Antarctic.

On the rare occasions that women were allowed to venture on expeditions, they often proved themselves to be invaluable assets: drawing maps, keeping assiduous records, and generally eliciting a more positive response from locals. These female adventurers also recorded their observations, producing letters, drawings, novels, and travel books that offered insights into other cultures. These narratives have inspired countless other women to follow in their footsteps.

From the mid-19th century, female European traveler writers such as Ida Pfeiffer (whose works were translated into seven different languages) began to rove over land and sea in pursuit of new discoveries. Although they were often derided as butterfly-net-wielding eccentrics, many of these travel writers were in fact experts who advanced scientific knowledge—among them biologist and botanical artist Marianne North and naturalist Isabella Bird—the first woman to be elected to the Royal Geographical Society.

THROUGH THE AGES

Adventurers

Despite the prejudices and obstacles that stood in their way, there have been many daring, determined, and courageous women who defied expectations and journeyed into the unknown—as travelers, explorers, mountaineers, aviators, and adventurers.